

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article appeared in a newspaper:

Global study on walking puts Hong Kong a step ahead

According to a recent study, Hong Kong people walk an average of 6,880 steps a day, compared with a world average of 4,961, making them the most active in the world.

Researchers said they hoped their study could help policymakers around the world design towns and cities that encourage more physical activity. "In cities that are more walkable, everyone tends to take more daily steps, whether male or female, young or old, healthy or obese," Jennifer Hicks, one of the researchers, said.

There are many studies suggesting there are health benefits of walking, even if only for 30 minutes a day. Some say walking fast is best, others believe walking slowly is good enough, and a few recommend a steep flight of steps. The advice for those who want to add a few extra years to their life is that, whenever possible, taking the footpath will pay off better than getting into a vehicle. Most Hong Kong people walk a lot, but out of necessity, not choice.

Studies say it is a good thing, though: walking prolongs life. It reduces the risk of diabetes, high blood pressure, respiratory and heart diseases, and even cancer. Walking is also free. It's convenient, requiring no special training or equipment, and it can be done at any age. Hong Kong people have obviously worked all that out.

Your group is doing a project on walking-friendly cities. You are meeting to discuss this. You may want to talk about:

- what makes Hong Kong suitable for walking
- what discourages people from walking in Hong Kong
- whether you think Hong Kong people are active
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like walking around the city?
2. Where is the best place in Hong Kong to go for a walk?
3. What things do people do while they are walking?
4. Why is walking a good exercise for old people?
5. What is the longest walk or hike you have taken?
6. Do you sometimes use the stairs rather than take the lift?
7. Do you find that walking helps you think?
8. Do you think people will walk less in the future?